STUDY AID · MATTHEW 21:23-46 · EPISODE 42 (#45 OF 58 IN THE PLAYLIST)



The Stone the *Builders Rejected*

By what authority?

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 21:23-46 in the LSB | 28:00 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: Is This the Parable That Got Jesus Killed?. Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 21:23-46. In the temple the chief priests and elders demand to know by what authority Jesus acts. He answers with a question about John's baptism, and when they refuse to answer, so does He. Then He tells two parables. In the first, a man's two sons are told to work in the vineyard: one says no but goes, the other says yes but does not. In the second, a landowner plants a vineyard, rents it to vine-growers, and sends slaves and finally his son, whom they kill. Jesus quotes Psalm 118:22, 'The stone which the builders rejected,' and says the kingdom of God will be taken from them and given to a nation producing its fruit. The leaders realize He is speaking about them.
- The question about authority asks who gave Jesus the right to teach, the formal recognition of a rabbi. The crowds already saw that He taught as one having authority (7:28-29). Jesus points them to John, the prophet who baptized Him, and to the Father's voice from heaven.
- 'A man had two sons' was a known way to begin a story (Luke 15:11). The point: obedience, not words, is doing the will of the Father. Tax collectors and prostitutes, who said no and then repented, are entering the kingdom before the leaders.
- The vineyard parable is built on Isaiah 5, where Israel is God's vineyard and God looks for justice and finds

> *"To the one who knows God and obeys him, Jesus Christ is the capstone or the cornerstone of protection.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"Putting both parables together, the message becomes clear. It's doing the will of God.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

bloodshed. Here the problem is the vine-growers, the leaders. Psalm 118:22 turns the rejected son into the chief corner stone.

- The lesson: to the one who knows God and obeys Him, Jesus Christ is the cornerstone of protection. To the one who refuses to know God and disobeys His will, Jesus Christ will be the source of punishment and destruction.

Find the Old Testament story under the parable

Jesus' vineyard parable retells Isaiah 5:1-7 and ends with Psalm 118:22. Reading those first shows who the vineyard, the owner, the tenants and the son are.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB. This is Episode 42 of the Matthew study (playlist item 45).

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 21:23-46 and turns to Matthew 3, 7, 12 and 15, John 8, Luke 15, Isaiah 5, Psalms 80 and 118, James 2 and Colossians 2. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 21:23-46
Read in full: the question of authority and two parables.

Matthew 7:28-29
As one having authority.

Matthew 3:13-17
John's baptism and the voice from heaven.

John 8:18
The Father bears witness about Me.

Luke 15:11
'A man had two sons.'

Isaiah 5:1-7
The song of the vineyard.

Psalm 80:8
A vine from Egypt.

Psalm 118:22-23
The stone which the builders rejected.

Matthew 15:14
Blind guides of the blind.

Matthew 12:7
I desire compassion, and not a sacrifice.

Matthew 7:21-23
Not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord.'

James 2:14-26
Faith without works is dead.

Colossians 2:6
As you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him.

Matthew 22:1-14
Coming next: the wedding feast.

Key verses in the LSB

"By what authority are You doing these things, and who gave You this authority?"
Matthew 21:23 (LSB)

"The stone which the builders rejected / Has become the chief corner stone."
Psalm 118:22 (LSB)

"Therefore as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him,"
Colossians 2:6 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

By what authority?

Ordination, John's baptism, and the two sons.

MATTHEW 21:23; 7:28-29

Who gave You this authority?

THE LEADERS · MATTHEW 21:23
"And when He entered the temple, the chief priests and the elders of the people came to Him while He was teaching, and said, "By what authority are You doing these things, and who gave You this authority?""

THE CROWDS · MATTHEW 7:29
"for He was teaching them as one having authority, and not as their scribes."

FROM THE VIDEO The day after He overturned the tables, Jesus is back in the temple teaching. The leaders ask, in effect: who ordained You?

FROM THE VIDEO The video explains semikhah, the laying on of hands to recognize a teacher, and says two witnesses were needed: John at the Jordan, and the Father's voice from heaven (John 8:18). John 8:18

BACKGROUND The Talmud's rule is three: 'From where do we derive that the ordination of elders is performed by three judges?' (Talmud Sanhedrin 13b). It grounds ordination in Moses laying hands on Joshua.

◆ Factbook: Rabbi ◆ Factbook: Moses ◆ Factbook: Joshua (son of Nun)

MATTHEW 21:24-27

From heaven or from men?

MATTHEW 21:25-26 (LSB)

TRAP

“The baptism of John was from what source, from heaven or from men?” And they began reasoning among themselves, saying, “If we say, ‘From heaven,’ He will say to us, ‘Then why did you not believe him?’ But if we say, ‘From men,’ we fear the crowd; for they all regard John as a prophet.””

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus' question is not a dodge. If John's baptism was from heaven, then the one John baptized and pointed to has heaven's authority.

FROM THE VIDEO They answer 'We do not know.' Leaders who should be guides are blind: 'they are blind guides of the blind' (15:14). Matthew 15:14

◆ Factbook: John the Baptist ◆ Factbook: Baptism

MATTHEW 21:28-32

A man had two sons

THE FIRST SON · MATTHEW 21:29

“And he answered and said, ‘I will not’; but afterward he regretted it and went.”

THE SECOND SON · MATTHEW 21:30

“And the man came to the second and said the same thing; and he answered and said, ‘I will, sir’; but he did not go.”

FROM THE VIDEO 'A man had two sons' was a familiar way to open a story, as in Luke 15:11. The question: which one did the will of his father? Luke 15:11

FROM THE VIDEO The message is doing the will of God (21:31). Compare 7:21: not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord' will enter. Matthew 7:21

FROM THE VIDEO The tax collectors and prostitutes believed John and repented. The leaders saw it and still did not regret afterward (21:32). Matthew 21:32

◆ Factbook: Parable ◆ Factbook: Tax collector ◆ Factbook: Repentance



By what authority?

James Tissot, The Chief Priests Ask Jesus by What Right Does He Act in This Way, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *"Putting both parables together, the message becomes clear. It's doing the will of God.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The landowner's vineyard

Isaiah 5, the wordplay, and the son the tenants killed.

ISAIAH 5:1-2; MATTHEW 21:33

The song of the vineyard

ISAIAH · ISAIAH 5:2

"He dug it all around, removed its stones, / And planted it with the choicest vine. / And He built a tower in the middle of it / And also hewed out a wine vat in it; / Then He hoped for it to produce good grapes, / But it produced only worthless ones."

JESUS · MATTHEW 21:33

""Listen to another parable. There was a landowner who planted a vineyard and put a wall around it and dug a wine press in it, and built a tower, and rented it out to vine-growers and went on a journey."

FROM THE VIDEO The wall, the wine press, the tower: Jesus is retelling Isaiah 5. Everyone listening would know the vineyard is Israel.

BACKGROUND Psalm 80:8 uses the same picture: 'You removed a vine from Egypt; / You drove out the nations and then You planted it.'

◆ Factbook: Isaiah ◆ Factbook: Book of Psalms

ISAIAH 5:7

Justice, but bloodshed

⚖ ISAIAH 5:7 (LSB) WORDPLAY

“For the vineyard of Yahweh of hosts is the house of Israel / And the men of Judah His delightful plant. / Thus He hoped for justice, but behold, bloodshed; / For righteousness, but behold, a cry of distress.”

FROM THE VIDEO In Hebrew the words sound alike: mishpat (justice) and mispach (bloodshed), tsedaqah (righteousness) and tse'aqah (a cry of distress). God looked for one and heard the other.

FROM THE VIDEO In Isaiah the vineyard itself is bad. In Jesus' parable the trouble is the vine-growers: the leaders put in charge of the vineyard.

◆ Factbook: Righteousness

MATTHEW 21:34-41

They will respect my son

MATTHEW 21:37-39 (LSB)

THE HEIR

“But afterward he sent his son to them, saying, ‘They will respect my son.’ But when the vine-growers saw the son, they said among themselves, ‘This is the heir; come, let us kill him and seize his inheritance.’ And they took him, and threw him out of the vineyard and killed him.”

FROM THE VIDEO The slaves are the prophets; the son is Jesus. Jesus is not indicting the people of Israel but the leaders who were supposed to care for the vineyard.

FROM THE VIDEO The video also suggests the tenants picture occupiers, as Rome and its appointed leaders held the land.

BACKGROUND The leaders pronounce their own sentence: 'He will bring those wretches to a wretched end' (21:41). Matthew 21:41

◆ Factbook: The Prophets (books) ◆ Factbook: God the Son



They took his slaves and beat one

Marten van Valckenborch, Parable of the Wicked Husbandmen (October), 1580-1590. Kunsthistorisches Museum, Vienna, via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *“Jesus indicts the ones who were supposed to care for this vineyard.*
>
> From the video

05 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The stone the builders rejected

Psalm 118:22, the warning, and the leaders' response.

PSALM 118:22-23; MATTHEW 21:42

The chief corner stone

THE PSALMIST · PSALM 118:22

"The stone which the builders rejected / Has become the chief corner stone."

JESUS · MATTHEW 21:42

"Jesus *said to them, "Did you never read in the Scriptures, / 'The stone which the builders rejected, / This has become the chief corner stone; / This came about from the Lord, / And it is marvelous in our eyes'?"

FROM THE VIDEO The rejected son becomes the stone that holds the building together. The video pictures it as a capstone or cornerstone of protection.

FROM THE VIDEO This is the same psalm the crowds sang at the entry (118:26). The builders rejected what the people welcomed.

◆ Factbook: Book of Psalms ◆ Factbook: Messiah

MATTHEW 21:43-44

Broken or scattered

MATTHEW 21:43-44 (LSB)

WARNING

"Therefore I say to you, the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a nation, producing the fruit of it. And he who falls on this stone will be broken to pieces; but on whomever it falls, it will scatter him like dust.""

FROM THE VIDEO The same stone protects those who build on it and crushes those who oppose it.

BACKGROUND 'Producing the fruit of it' ties back to John's call to 'bear fruit in keeping with repentance' (3:8) and to the fig tree with leaves only (21:19). Matthew 3:8 Matthew 21:19

◆ Factbook: Kingdom of heaven ◆ Factbook: Remnant

MATTHEW 21:45-46

They understood

MATTHEW 21:45-46 (LSB)

TURNING POINT

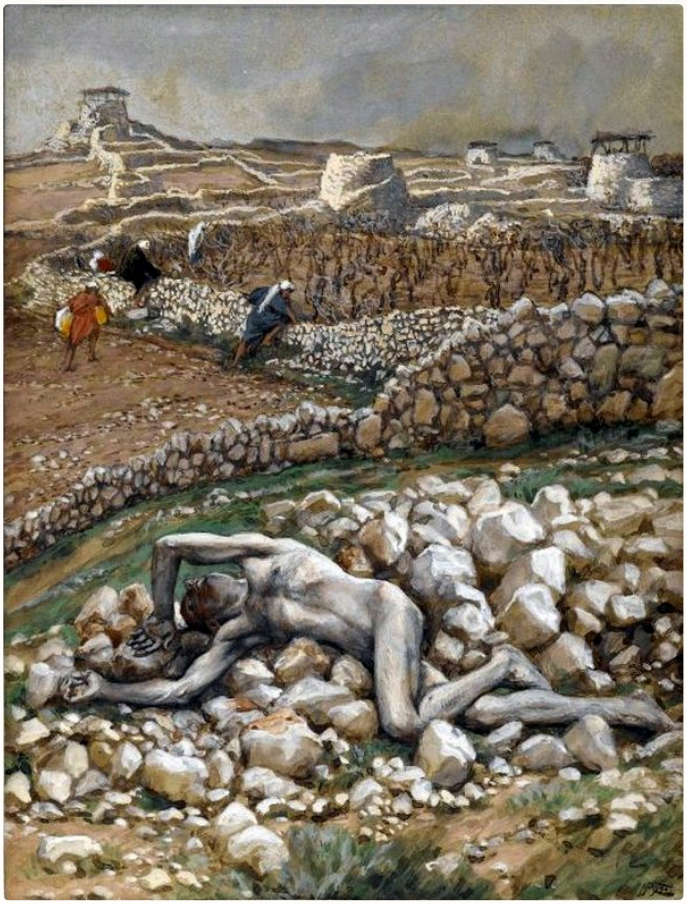
"And when the chief priests and the Pharisees heard His parables, they understood that He *was speaking about them. And although they were seeking to seize Him, they feared the crowds, because they were regarding Him to be a prophet."

FROM THE VIDEO They understood the parable perfectly, and it made them want Him dead. This may be the parable that got Jesus killed.

FROM THE VIDEO Obedience and mercy are two sides of the same coin: 'If you had known what this means, “I desire compassion, and not a sacrifice”' (12:7). Matthew 12:7

FROM THE VIDEO So walk in Him: 'as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him' (Colossians 2:6). Faith without works is dead (James 2:26). James 2:26

◆ Factbook: Pharisees ◆ Factbook: Mercy



This is the heir; come, let us kill him

James Tissot, The Son of the Vineyard, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *It reveals the dividing line between those who truly know God and those who only know religion.*
>
> From the video

06

Who's who in 21:23-46

What the video says, then a short background note.

The chief priests and elders

John the Baptist

VIDEO Challenge His authority; represented by the vine-growers.

BACKGROUND In 21:45 Matthew names the chief priests and Pharisees as the listeners who understood.

Matthew 21:23 | Matthew 21:45 | ◆ Sanhedrin | ◆ Pharisees | ◆ Elder

VIDEO The prophet whose baptism was from heaven, a witness to Jesus.

BACKGROUND The crowds all regarded him as a prophet (21:26).

Matthew 21:25-26 | Matthew 3:13-17 | ◆ John the Baptist

The two sons

VIDEO One says no and goes; one says yes and does not.

BACKGROUND Only Matthew has this parable.

Matthew 21:28-31

Tax collectors and prostitutes

VIDEO Said no to God, then repented at John's preaching.

BACKGROUND Compare Luke 3:12; 7:29-30.

Matthew 21:31-32 | Luke 7:29-30 | ◆ Tax collector

The landowner, slaves and son

VIDEO God, the prophets, and Jesus.

BACKGROUND Mark 12:1-12 and Luke 20:9-19 tell the same parable.

Mark 12:1-12 | ◆ The Prophets (books) | ◆ Parable | ◆ Parable of the wicked tenants

The vine-growers

VIDEO The leaders who should have tended God's vineyard.

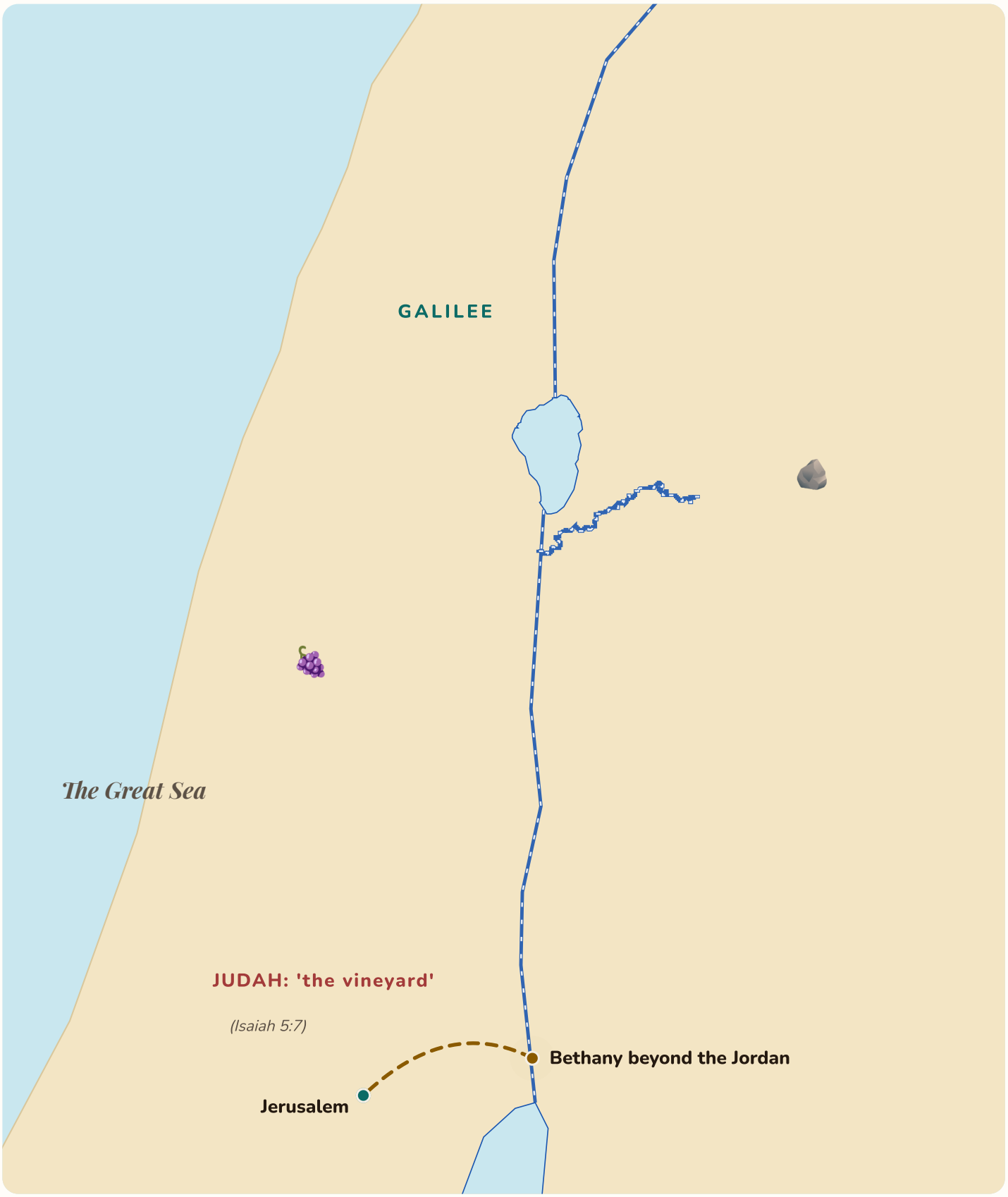
BACKGROUND They reason, 'This is the heir' (21:38).

Matthew 21:38 | ◆ Parable of the wicked tenants

07 · BACKGROUND

From heaven or from men?

Pins outlined in the video's color are places in this passage; the gold pin marks John's traditional baptizing site.



● Named in the video ● Background

The dashed line links John's baptizing site to the temple, the two places behind 'from heaven or from men?' The baptism site is traditional. Coastline, Dead Sea and most rivers: Natural Earth (public domain). Sea of Galilee outline and the Yarmuk River: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).

Jerusalem VIDEO

The temple, where He is asked 'By what authority?' (21:23).

- ◆ Factbook: Jerusalem
- ◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

Bethany beyond the Jordan BACKGROUND

Where John was baptizing (John 1:28); site traditional.

- ◆ Factbook: John the Baptist
- ◆ Factbook: Bethany beyond the Jordan

08

Key terms

Semikhah

VIDEO

The laying on of hands to ordain a teacher; the Talmud requires three (Sanhedrin 13b).

- ◆ Factbook: Rabbi
- ◆ Factbook: Ordination

Elders

BACKGROUND

Lay leaders of the people, part of the Sanhedrin with the chief priests and scribes.

- ◆ Factbook: Sanhedrin
- ◆ Factbook: Elder

Vine-growers

VIDEO

Tenant farmers who rented a vineyard and owed the owner part of the crop.

- ◆ Factbook: Parable of the wicked tenants

Chief corner stone

VIDEO

LSB 'chief corner stone' (Psalm 118:22); literally head of the corner, the key stone of a building.

- ◆ Factbook: Cornerstone

Heir

BACKGROUND

The son who inherits; killing him was meant to seize the inheritance.

09 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

ἐξουσία

exousia G1849

Authority, the right to act.

Greek · Matt 21:23

μεταμέλομαι

metamelomai G3338

To regret, change one's mind.

Greek · Matt 21:29, 32

γεωργός

geōrgos `G1092`

Farmer, vine-grower, tenant.

Greek · Matt 21:41

◆ Factbook: Parable of the wicked tenants

κεφαλὴ γωνίας

kephalē gōnias `G1137`

Head of the corner; LSB 'chief corner stone.'

Greek · Matt 21:42

◆ Factbook: Cornerstone

λικμάω

likmaō `G3039`

To winnow, scatter like chaff. Look up: BDAG, λικμάω.

Greek · Matt 21:44

מִשְׁפָּט

mishpat `H4941`

Justice, judgment.

Hebrew · Isa 5:7

מִשְׂפָּח

mispach `H4939`

Bloodshed (a pun on mishpat).

Hebrew · Isa 5:7

צְדָקָה

tsedaqah `H6666`

Righteousness.

Hebrew · Isa 5:7

◆ Factbook: Righteousness

צְעָקָה

tse'aqah `H6818`

Outcry, cry of distress (a pun on tsedaqah).

Hebrew · Isa 5:7

פִּנָּה

pinnah `H6438`

Corner.

Hebrew · Ps 118:22

◆ Factbook: Cornerstone

10

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

Tenant vineyards

Absentee landowners in first-century Judea and Galilee often rented land to tenants for a share of the crop. A new vineyard took several years to bear, and disputes over payment were common, which makes the parable's setting realistic.

Ordination in the sources

The Talmud discusses ordination ('semikhah') by laying on of hands: 'From where do we derive that the ordination of elders is performed by three judges?' (Talmud Sanhedrin 13b). How formal ordination was in Jesus' day is debated; the sources are later.

Psalm 118 in the week

The crowds sang Psalm 118:26 as He entered. Now Jesus quotes 118:22 against the leaders. The same psalm frames both the welcome and the rejection.

SOURCED Early witnesses

> *Therefore He brought in both harlots and publicans, that they might provoke them to jealousy.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 67, on 21:31-32. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

> *Many things does He intimate by this parable, God's providence, which had been exercised towards them from the first; their murderous disposition from the beginning*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 68, on 21:33-41. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

DEBATED Where scholars differ

Who are the tenants?

Most read the vine-growers as Jerusalem's leaders, as 21:45 says. The video adds the idea of occupiers tied to Rome; that is an extension, not the text's own identification.

To whom is the kingdom given?

'A nation producing the fruit of it' (21:43) has been read as the church of Jews and Gentiles, as the faithful remnant, or as new leaders over Israel. Matthew does not name it.

Cornerstone or capstone?

The Hebrew 'head of the corner' can mean a foundation cornerstone or a top stone. Translations differ; the LSB has 'chief corner stone.'

CAREFUL READING Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- The video says 'chief priests and scribes' come to Him; the LSB of 21:23 has 'the chief priests and the elders of the people,' and 21:45 has 'the chief priests and the Pharisees.'
- The question about John's baptism is 21:25; the video says 21:2.
- In 21:46 they were 'seeking to seize Him,' not just to find fault.
- The video says ordination needed two rabbis. The Talmud's rule is three judges (Sanhedrin 13b), and how formal ordination was in Jesus' time is debated.

- The idea that the chief stone was a capstone placed on parapets is offered without a source; the LSB reads 'chief corner stone.'
- Psalm 118 has no title naming its author, so calling it a psalm of David is a tradition, not the text.

11 · BACKGROUND

From Moses to the Talmud

Coral dots mark what Matthew 21:23-46 echoes or this episode covers. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

C. 1406 BC DEBATED
Moses lays hands on Joshua
Numbers 27:23

C. 740-700 BC
Isaiah's song of the vineyard
Isaiah 5:1-7 *Remez: 21:33*

UNDATED DEBATED
'The stone which the builders rejected'
Psalm 118:22 *Quoted: 21:42*

C. AD 28 DEBATED
John baptizes at the Jordan
Matthew 3:13-17

C. AD 30 DEBATED
'By what authority?' and two parables
Matthew 21:23-46 *This episode*

C. AD 500 DEBATED
The Talmud discusses ordination by three
Numbers 27:23

12

Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Acts 4:10-12
Peter: the stone rejected by you builders
ADDED

1 Peter 2:6-8
A stone of stumbling
ADDED

Isaiah 28:16
A costly cornerstone in Zion
ADDED

Daniel 2:34-35
A stone that crushes the kingdoms
ADDED

Hebrews 1:1-2

God spoke through prophets, then a Son

ADDED

13

Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1. Why did Jesus answer the leaders with a question about John?
2. Which son are you more like, and where?
3. What would the first listeners hear when Jesus began to describe a wall, a wine press and a tower?
4. Why does the parable put the blame on the vine-growers rather than the vineyard?
5. How can the same stone be protection for some and destruction for others?
6. What is the difference between knowing about Jesus and knowing Him?

14

Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson: to the one who knows God and obeys Him, Jesus Christ is the capstone or the cornerstone of protection. To the one who refuses to know God and disobeys His will, Jesus Christ will be the source of punishment and destruction. The dividing line runs between those who truly know God and those who only know religion. Obeying God is not a legalistic prerequisite for the kingdom; as James 2 says, good deeds are the evidence of faith. As you received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him (Colossians 2:6).

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

name one thing you have told God 'I will, sir' about and not done. Take the first step on it this week, and tell one person so they can ask you about it.

> *To the one who knows God and obeys him, Jesus Christ is the capstone or the cornerstone of protection.*
>
> From the video

15

Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ David ◆ Joshua (son of Nun) ◆ Moses ◆ Egypt ◆ John the Baptist ◆ Jordan River
◆ Isaiah ◆ Pharisees ◆ Repentance ◆ Judgment ◆ Galilee ◆ Baptism ◆ Righteousness
◆ Kingdom of heaven ◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Jerusalem ◆ Book of Psalms ◆ God the Son
◆ John Chrysostom ◆ Gentiles ◆ Judea ◆ Mercy ◆ Perea ◆ Sanhedrin ◆ Scribe
◆ Sea of Galilee ◆ Babylonian Talmud ◆ Tax collector ◆ Daniel (the prophet) ◆ Priest ◆ Compassion
◆ Messiah ◆ Parable ◆ Rabbi ◆ Remnant ◆ Church ◆ Bethany beyond the Jordan ◆ Cornerstone
◆ Elder ◆ Fig tree ◆ Ordination ◆ Parable of the wicked tenants ◆ Triumphal entry

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Talmud Sanhedrin: Sefaria, William Davidson Edition (CC BY-NC). Images: Wikimedia Commons (James Tissot, Brooklyn Museum; Marten van Valckenborch, Kunsthistorisches Museum; all public domain). Map data: Natural Earth (public domain) and OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).